outsiders had ventured into before and conventional wisdom would have expected that the survey party would be decimated. Amazingly, the tribes simply let them through. In fact, porters had hitherto been brought from other regions; now they were simply replaced by Mishmis themselves. This was a huge development and a major feather in the paramilitary force's cap. In this changing scenario, it was decided to send a survey team along with a road-building party into the Lohit Valley and explore the possibility of opening a trade route with Southwest China via Rima in Tibet. This group was successful in starting work on a bridle path up to Walong, no mean feat at the time.

Similarly, the Mishmi Exploration Survey of 1912 that included Captains George Bailey and S. F. Morshead, had little difficulty in traversing the lower reaches of the Dibang River and making it to Mipi in the valley of the Matun River, one of the key tributaries that flow north of Anini. There the party ran into a party of Khamba Tibetans who were not only friendly, but even offered to provide guides who would lead them into outer Tibet. Following the ill-fated British military expedition of 1911, the entire region hitherto referred to as 'un-administered' was now to be known as the North East Frontier Tracts (NEFT). In addition, after the fall of the Qing dynasty in China, reports reaching Assam indicated that the Tibetans had expelled all Chinese officials and troops and declared themselves independent. For the British surveyors, this was a godsent opportunity to not only follow the road to Pemako and Po-me but also explore the hitherto unknown reaches of the mythical Brahmaputra bend.

On completion of the survey, Bailey and Morshead were given permission to return to Mipi with an added caveat that should the local and Tibetan authorities allow it, they should try and explore the frontier between the Siang River Valley and Tawang, moving along the northern side of the watershed while surveying the important geographical features. Accordingly, the two British officers doubled back to Mipi with ten hand-picked porters in April 1913. During their previous visit, anticipating that sanction would be given, they had dumped two months' worth of rations at Mipi. The first half of May was spent laying out staging points of rations as far as possible along the route to Yonggyap-la (13,020 feet). Finally, in pouring rain that made progress extremely difficult, the party of twelve along with three local guides set off from Mipi on 16 May 1913.